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Confronting

Technology in Higher Education

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Introduction

Today, information technology is crucial to business operations and helps higher education institutions streamline business operations and achieve a competitive advantage. The Internet and its related technologies are defined as technologies that enable businesses and schools to operate, people to work and learn, and people to work together. In this dynamic environment, new technology solutions are developed every day to solve business problems. These new solutions continually provide consumers, businesses, higher education institutions, and global institutions with solutions to their consumer and business requirements. Furthermore, every day a new and even more sophisticated update of the current technology emerges to take its place. Many recent studies have shown that technology can help boost business productivity and improve both the speed and accuracy of work processes.

The principal parties to information technology support include students, school staff, school administrators, and local businesses. The technological basis is to achieve the school's education objectives and to gain a competitive advantage while preparing students for the future. Leaders in higher education need to manage and integrate the new technology into the teaching and learning environment.

The impact of information technology on students is that they must be willing to learn new technology skills, work together, and learn from other students and faculty. However, in this kind of cooperative learning, technology may directly impact student outcomes or interact with technological features to indirectly impact outcomes.

The intent of confronting technology in higher education is for leadership to explore the latest educational technology and gain ideas for improving the teaching and learning experience at their institution. The intent of using technology in higher education includes: 1) improving the quality of learning, 2) providing students with everyday information technology, 3) widening access to education and training, 4) responding to the technological imperative, 5) reducing the costs of education, and 6) improving the cost-effectiveness of education. The same kind of technology has not only revolutionized global commerce and communication but has also greatly affected how colleges and universities operate.

By confronting technology in higher education, education leaders can better prepare their institution in a new era of higher education. A new era of higher education is a new approach to community partnerships and cooperative learning (Goldberg, 2003).

Analysis

This prospectus describes a very broad range of topics, and, more specifically, the impact of new technologies on the information society. In today's workplace and especially in a knowledge-based economy, students need the opportunity to communicate with one another as well as with their teachers, and learning is as much social as an individual activity. In addition, students are looking for flexible and more responsive forms of education and training. Students in this environment interact with one another through their personal computers in a variety of ways.

In contrast, within a classroom, teachers are accustomed to interacting with the most outgoing students, whereas in the technology environment, all students interact, including less sociable students. This type of cooperative learning encourages students to work together and learn from each other.

In a new era of higher education, teachers and students seek to collaborate with each other and learn in teams. Both teachers and teachers are learning about technology along with students in addition to promoting cooperative learning. In this type of learning environment, both teachers and students can see positive ways to approach new technology.

Community partnerships and learning communities allow students who previously have had little success in learning activities may feel very successful in a technology-rich classroom that emphasizes meaningful and authentic tasks. Learning communities are really about bringing students, faculty and disciplines together in more integrated and meaningful ways.

In a new era of higher education, education leaders need to consider the needs of students at risk of educational failure when developing the technology plan. In addition, they need to ensure the equitable use of educational technologies for all students and develop a strategy to provide all students with adequate access to technology. They also need to address policy issues related to the use of technology for learning. In addition, they need to ensure that school facilities are adequate to support technology networking that fosters learning, and that there are secure sources of on-site technical support to answer teacher and student questions and keep the technology running smoothly.

The technologies supporting teaching and learning include email, text messaging, online chat, Weblog, presentation software, Web conferencing, the World Wide Web, cell phones, PDAs, and the new video iPod—"learning to go" (iPod in Education). These new technologies have a major impact on the educational system. There are also portable devices and wireless connectivity (Wi-Fi), making it easy for students to learn on the go.

Some students may choose to learn on the road, having mobile access to class assignments, contacts, emails, schedules, and other online resources.

One of the new technologies I am excited about is Apple's new video iPod. This product is being marketed as "iPod in Education". With the new iPod, students will be able to subscribe to a course content feed and automatically receive it on their iPod. Podcasting will allow teachers to easily publish (or podcast) lectures, photos, or foreign language drills, along with a myriad of other course content (iPod in Education).

Technology is also leading to major structural changes in the management and organization of teaching. In addition, new technologies have the potential not only to enrich existing classrooms but, equally important, to enable institutions to reach out to new target groups as lifelong learners, members of the workforce, and people with physical disabilities (Bates, 2000).

In conclusion, technology now plays a central role in everyone's life, as well as in businesses, universities, and colleges. For this reason, educational leadership needs to find new ways to meet the growing demand for lifelong learning. Using technology in teaching can help universities and colleges serve the public more cost-effectively and, in particular, prepare students for a technology-based society.

Recognizing that there are many technology solutions, this document neither details how to implement the various recommendation strategies nor, more importantly, discusses the relative advantages and disadvantages of each new technology. Instead, it provides an overview of the available technologies in the technology sector, especially those offered for higher education.

I particularly liked this project, primarily because I have extensive practical experience integrating computer technology and the Internet, and for this reason, I want to focus on technology as the basis for my dissertation topic.

Finally, technology in higher education is summed up best by Gates, "School districts need to have a plan to use PCs to improve education. The first step is to enlist community support, establish a solid technical infrastructure, and train teachers. Next, PCs and the Internet should be integrated into the curriculum, with PCs serving as learning tools for students. Finally, digital methods can transform learning by making it easier to create and maintain core presentations, freeing teachers to create more in-depth material and personalized instruction." (Gates, pg. 401) In addition, I think that technology allows students, faculty, and administrators to leverage information technology to stay ahead of the competition, better enables schools to serve their students, and ultimately increase their productivity.

References

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